

The Genesis Melody

Note: there is an audio version of this guide on <https://thegenesismelody.web.app>
It works well to listen as your eyes follow along. Look for the audio in the upper right.

A Quick Foreword

Hey. Hi. Before we get started, I wanted to let you know that I love you. Yes, that's extremely awkward to say in our generation, but it really shouldn't be. Of course, I don't know you, and we've never met. So my love for you is a bit limited, but you are an Image of God like me, so... I love you. Oops, I said it again. My goal here is not to convince you of anything at all, but to invite you to receive a gift from God in His Word, so that we can know|love Him more.

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Introduction and Motivation

This guide is organized into three main sections:

1. **Introduction and Motivation** - The part you are about to read.
2. **Melody Observations** - A detailed look at Genesis 1-22, broken into three parts:
 - a. **Genesis 1-7**: The Template of the Melody
 - b. **Genesis 8-11**: The Second Round of the Melody
 - c. **Genesis 11:27-22:19**: Cycles Three to Seven with AvrahamFrom there, this guide will pivot when we read the details of the seventh cycle's collapse and re-creation moments. We'll let the story guide us, but something will happen naturally when we read about Avraham's Test and the oath that Yahweh makes.
3. **The Melody Points to Jesus** - When you read the Bible, it's tempting to read only the parts about Jesus and the early church. However, God's grand song is best experienced when the Old Testament paves the way. This guide is the same. You should expect to enjoy the final section about Jesus the most, but do try to read the earlier sections first. Think of it like a movie: the climax means more when you haven't skipped the first hour.

Summary: What is The Genesis Melody?

When **you** approach the Bible, what do you see there? Well, what do you expect to see there? Over time we have been trained to see only some parts of the Bible, and our expectations are often at odds with our ability to simply receive the message. This guide will focus on reading Genesis 1-23 trying to see patterns. The goal is to approach the text as a blank slate. To be honest, I'm not capable of doing that either, but it's important to know the mindset we're seeking for. Shaping the Bible to meet our expectations is rather pointless. The goal is to open ourselves up, so that we can be shaped by the Bible. I'm really excited to share with you some things I've gotten to see in Genesis. Through this writing process I've felt the guiding presence of the Spirit myself and I'm just amazed at what these authors have been able to create.

The Hebrew Bible, the Old Testament, was carefully written by humans partnering with the work of the Spirit over the course of hundreds of years to make God known to us.¹ As a result, it is a VERY dense, beautiful collection of ancient scrolls with many layers to unpack. Readers who start at the beginning, myself included, see only a small fraction of the depth the authors are communicating. However, the goal of this guide is not to learn everything. We'll choose to focus on just one significant layer that is often overlooked.

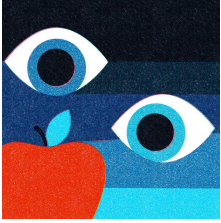
There is a clear, repeated creation melody that runs throughout the Hebrew Bible and into the New Testament. Once you have eyes to see and ears to hear how the authors replay the notes, you won't be able to miss them as you continue to read the Bible. This song starts with God bringing about **creation**, life, and blessing. Then, characteristic human **choices** and **division** cause things to come to a head in a **collapse**. God, however, uses a collapse to once again bring about **creation**, life, and blessing from the non-life. Understanding how God continually brings about and sustains life is foundational not just in the Bible, but in our own lives as well.

So the authors of the Bible provide a decoder ring, beginning on page one, to unlock the rest of the story.

Before we get started, I should explain the title. The word genesis means two things to us: first, it refers to the scroll of Genesis, but it also simply means what the word means. The word genesis comes from the Greek γένεσις (génēsis), meaning "origin, source, beginning, or birth". Matthew liked this word and so do I. So when choosing a title for a repeated creation pattern, a genesis, that is easily seen in the scroll of Genesis, it seemed only fitting to call it **The Genesis Melody**. However, don't be fooled! The author of life keeps creating well beyond the pages of Genesis.

Background

The melody is discussed at length in the BibleProject Genesis Classroom series, namely, these five courses:

				
Heaven and Earth	Adam to Noah	Noah to Abraham	Abraham	Jacob

From these courses the most succinct summaries of what Tim Mackie calls "The Melody" are found in session 11 of the Abraham class, titled [The Genesis 1-11 Melody Repeats](#), or sessions 2 and 3 of the Jacob class, [The Thematic Melody of Genesis 1-9](#) and [Abraham Replays the Melody](#). However, if you are new to the melody concept, it's best to start from the beginning. Through his studies, Tim began to see how the authors replayed similar concepts, often in the same order, that felt like the melody of a song. It emerged after years of teaching, exploring commentaries, and discussing the text with reading communities. These concepts have become so important to Tim that he starts nearly every course with a recap of The Melody, see the Joseph class, [The Thematic Melody of the Hebrew Bible](#), or the Ezekiel class, [The Main Themes of the Torah](#). This guide builds on those insights, to lay out the melody for you and help us all meditate on the purpose. What were these authors communicating by intentionally structuring the text in this way?

Why Study the Melody

What is the value in seeing the structure of the melody? The main focus in the Genesis courses is how the repeated notes should be ringing in our ears to link parts of the melody. Parallel stories might be separated by many chapters, but with only a few distinct notes the authors can put them side-by-side in your mind.² One story informs the other, and both benefit from the

connection. Let's take a short but deep dive to consider one specific example: Genesis 3:6-7a. You probably know this text well. Notice the key words as you read it again.

3:6 and the woman **saw** that **the tree** **was good** **for eating**,
and that it was desirable to **the eyes**,
and that the tree was desirable **to make one wise**,
and **she took** from its fruit and **she ate**;
and **she gave** also to her husband with her, and **he ate**.
7 **and the eyes of both of them were opened**,

The best way to hear what the authors are communicating in this passage is **not** to focus on these words alone. In isolation, these words have some value, but to fully grasp the verse, you have to spend time thinking about how it connects to the greater narrative. As we will soon discuss, this verse is a **Choice** in the first round of the melody. Let's compare it to the Choice in Melody four, Genesis 16:2-4, by reading the story of Sarai, Avram, and Hagar. Note, Avram is just an alternative spelling of Abram, who will later be renamed Abraham. In the BibleProject translation, you will see a few surprising spellings to help us more faithfully pronounce the original Hebrew names. Additionally, Yahweh, God's personal name, is used when appropriate instead of translating it to God or LORD. If that makes you feel uncomfortable, just replace "Yahweh" with "God" as you read (that's fine).

Notice the repeated words here that echo the Eden passage above.

16:2 And **Sarai** said to **Avram**,
"Look, please! Yahweh has restrained me from **giving birth**.
Please, **go into** **my slave-girl**.
Perhaps I can be **built up** by means of her."
And **Avram** listened to the voice of **Sarai**.
3 And **Sarai, the wife of Avram** **took** **Hagar, her Egyptian slave-girl**,
at the end of ten years of Avram dwelling in the land of Canaan,
and **she gave** her to **Avram** her husband **as a wife**.
4 And **he went into** **Hagar** and she became **pregnant**,
and she **saw** that she was **pregnant**,
and her mistress **became cursed in her eyes**.

The reuse pattern goes from taking a piece of fruit to taking an image of God. That escalated quickly! These two Choices are separated by 13 chapters, but they are clear hyperlinks. If you set them alongside one another, you can see how they are similar and how they are different. Additionally, they are both inversions of an earlier Choice pattern from Genesis 2:18-22, where God himself sees what is not **good**, then takes, **builds**, and **gives**. God models correct

behavior for us before we face our choice. There's something to think about there. Let's read that story and consider how all three passages inform one another.

2:18 and Yahweh God said,

"It is not **good** for **the human** to be **alone**
I will make a **help-counterpart** for him

...

21 and Yahweh caused to fall a deep sleep on the human and he slept

and he **took** one from his sides

and he closed the **flesh** of its place

22 and Yahweh **built** the side which he **took** from the human into **woman**,
and he brought her to the human

The authors signal connections through both word repetition and shared symbols.² They are clues to help us become better readers, and it's remarkable the depth of understanding your group can reach as you hold repeated stories in your mind. God saw good, tov, טוב, in Genesis 1 seven times, ending in a "very good." Humans, however, characteristically **see** what is **good for themselves** in their own eyes: we **take** and **eat** (an image to consume in this case), then **give** (send out non-life choices), as shown in 3:6 and 16:3. But God **sees** what is not **good**, something in our world that is broken: He **takes** and **builds** (multiplies abundance), then **gives** (sends out life). Both the similarities and the differences pop out as significant when you compare rounds of the melody. Finally, in both human replays, the male character is said to have "listened to the voice of his wife," instead of trusting God. Who will you trust to receive the knowledge of good and bad? When you see a broken situation will you act to send out life?

Structure

For the purposes of this guide, we will consider a four-part melody that is repeated seven times from Genesis 1 to 22: Creation (C1), Choice (C2), the Division of Relationships (D), and Collapse (C3). The repeated pattern can be broken down in many ways and variations are welcome as we all understand the Hebrew authors slightly differently. Additionally, as the melody repeats beyond Genesis 22, the authors get more creative with twists and inversions that make this four-part model too strict; however, for our purposes here, it works pretty well.

The cycle goes around like a circle.



Once you firmly grasp the melody, the stories from Genesis 1 through 23 will lock into place.

Pattern Breakers!

Now, you might be thinking that this all seems pretty gloom and doom. Is life really an inevitable downward spiral that ends in a collapse? That's depressing. No! Of course not. This is the **characteristic** human pattern, **NOT** the way to life. I think these authors love to make patterns just to break them. Let's look at Genesis 5 for a moment which uses a very clear pattern. The text below is super long, but I bet you can see the point I'm making about pattern breaking in two seconds.

15 And Mahalalel lived sixty-five years,
and he caused the birth of Jared.
16 And Mahalalel lived eight hundred and thirty years after he became the father of Jared,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.
17 And all the days of Mahalalel were eight hundred and ninety-five years,
and he died.

18 And Yared lived one hundred and sixty-two years,
and he caused the birth of Enoch.
19 And Yared lived eight hundred years after he became the father of Enoch,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.
20 And all the days of Yared were nine hundred and sixty-two years,
and he died.

21 And Enoch lived sixty-five years,
and he caused the birth of Methuselah,
22 and Enoch walked with God three hundred years after he became the father of Methuselah,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters,
23 and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years,
24 and Enoch walked with God; and he was not, for God took him.

The point is NOT the pattern. The point is the pattern breakers! As we listen for the notes in the melody, be especially on the lookout for pattern breaker moments. God can work through characteristic human choices, but see what God can do with the pattern breakers. People who choose to listen to God's voice get an opportunity to become partners in creation, not just in Genesis 1-23, but throughout the Bible. But I'm getting ahead of myself. First, we need to see the pattern.

Melody Observations

This middle section is the most academic, but also the heart of this guide. If you are a person who spends time in biblical scholarship, to you I say "Enjoy!" However, if you are a normal person without a rich background in Bible study, then to you I say "You can do it!". Try to be like the people Paul met in Berea in Acts 16:11 "They received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if what Paul said was true."

Genesis 1-7: The Melody Template

Instead of abstractly describing the characteristics of the notes, let's look at **the template** of The Genesis Melody provided in Genesis 1-7. These early chapters of Genesis are intentionally placed at the start of this massive collection as an introduction to the entire work. They will plant seeds for themes that will take volumes to unpack. If we allow them to properly shape our imagination and world view, we will become better Bible readers.

Through prayer, meditation, study, and time the biblical authors have shared God's message with us, but work is also necessary to receive it today. How would Jesus have expressed this point? In John 4:37-38 Jesus quotes an unusual phrase: "Thus the saying 'One sows and another reaps' is true... Others have done the hard work, and you have reaped the benefits of their labor." Parables can have more than one meaning, a common Hebrew Bible technique, but, for our theme study, the seed sown represents the Wisdom of God planted in His Word. These authors have worked with the Spirit to plant the key insights, but communication requires work from both the speaker and the listener. We have to put in time together with the Spirit to convert words into a relationship, so that we can live in a right relationship with Him. The authors use analogies that we can understand, like seed or light, but it all centers around taking on God's view of reality as truth. The only way to reap this freely given fruit is by meditating on it over time, then living it out in our lives. Let's get started by looking for the four-part melody in Genesis 1-7 using the table below.

As you read the text, note that the name Elohim is yet another name for God, a bit less personal than Yahweh. Again, feel free to translate "Elohim" as "God" if it makes you feel more comfortable. Also, Ruakh is a Hebrew word which means Spirit, wind, or breath, more on that later.

Name	Chapters	Distinctive Notes
Melody Cycle 1 Creation 	Genesis 1:1 - 2:3 plus 2:4-15	After the seven-word Hebrew title of Genesis 1:1, we read about the precreation state of watery chaos, a standard image for nothing at that point in history. However, with the presence of Elohim about to act, hovering as Ruakh over the face of the waters, we have hope. Elohim speaks to create light and divides those chaos waters to bring order to the sea, sky, and land in Days 1-3. He then fills those spaces with inhabitants in Days 4-6, starting with the lights in the sky, which are called signs. He makes living beings to fill those spaces, giving them a blessing to be fruitful and multiply. Ultimately, God creates the human in His image, male and female He created them, which He sees as “very good.” Finally, on the 7th day, God rests, i.e., takes up residence and rules without conflict. In the imagination of the Ancient Near East, when a ruler rests, it is a time of shalom, peace within the land. We know this story well, thinking of it as a one-time creation event, but we need to keep reading to realize that creation is a cycle. It will repeat!³ Still in the Creation section, Genesis 2:4-6 offers another perspective of non-life, a barren desert without water. God brings about life first via a stream, then the human, and finally trees, all in fun Hebrew wordplay. Again, God’s life is present, gently breathing the breath of life into the human.
Melody Cycle 1 Choice 	Genesis 2:16 - 3:24	The Choice portion of the melody starts with the divine command not to eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and bad. However, between the divine command and the Fall, the authors insert an example of Yahweh seeing, taking, building, and giving in 2:18-22. Unlike Yahweh, the humans see what is good in their eyes, then take, eat, and give non-life. The inevitable consequences follow. God acknowledges the unfortunate new state of His creation but makes some promises worth noting on the way out, see Genesis 3:15.
Melody Cycle 1 Division 	Genesis 4:1 - 4:24, 6:1 - 6:12	Outside of Eden, the next generation escalates the spiral of Division. As predicted in Genesis 3:16, they <i>conceive</i> for themselves instead of <i>receiving</i> from God, then experience great anguish. Cain kills Abel. Lamech takes two wives and murders a boy for striking him. The Sons of Elohim see and take the beautiful, tov, daughters of humanity in a parallel spiritual rebellion. We end up with the Nephilim, and the whole land is ruined by Genesis 6:12. If Genesis 1 had been a singular creation event then the whole cosmos would have been a very short, rather pointless, project. Fortunately for us, creation, life, and blessing are repeated notes in God’s song.
Melody Cycle 1 Collapse 	Genesis 6:13 - 7:24	The Collapse here is one we all know well. God brings about a great leveling act to cleanse the land via the Flood.⁶ This is a clear return to the Genesis 1:2 precreation state. By the end of Genesis 7, the world is again in the same watery chaos image of nothing, minus one small difference... a boat, covered with atonement, preserving seed. This symbol of God preserving life is of no small significance for you and me. Noah, seven other people, and a whole bunch of animals sit and wait until Yahweh does it again. “How long? Oh LORD?” the poets say. How long until You do it again?

Genesis 1-7: Pattern Breakers!

In the same way that Genesis 1-7 is The Template for the melody, it is also the template for pattern breakers! Clearly, Enoch and Noah don't follow the characteristic division and collapse cycle, but there is also a delightful ski jump at the end of chapter 4. From 4:1 to 4:24 we see characteristic human choices to establish the pattern. In those verses, Eve claims to have made a man all by herself in comparison to Yahweh. The authors use clever wordplay by noting only that Cain was **conceived**, the Hebrew root harah (הרה), with no mention of him being a **son**, the Hebrew word ben (בן). Cain, however, is invited by God to be a pattern breaker in the next generation. He can rule over sin, but instead he chooses the path of non-life. Then Cain's wife will also **conceive**, but again no mention of their child, a different Enoch, being a **son**. We have already seen where that path spirals out of control in the Division section above. Let's skip to verse 25, where we will see something new that you won't find on the Division spiral.

In the closing section of chapter 4, verses 25 and 26, we start with intentionally repeated words from verse 1, "Adam knew his wife again," but things go differently this time! First, right at this pivot, the Hebrew name for Adam changes from The Adam, i.e. "The Human", to just Adam, a personal name. Conversely, Eve's name was used in verse 1, but now she called only "Adam's wife" to emphasize their union over individuality. Next, the authors hint that something is new by only stating that she **bears a son** (yalad ben) with no mention of her **conceiving**.

4:1 Now, the human knew his wife Eve,
and she conceived and she gave birth

4:25 and Adam knew his wife again
and she gave birth to a son,

Obviously, she did **conceive** for every birth. She clearly became pregnant at some point, but the authors do not mention it, since this birth is not all about Eve. Finally, Adam's wife shows her new perspective by giving the glory to Elohim, not herself. She sees life as a gift to be received instead of an act accomplished by herself. Then it hits you... She is **the first to break the pattern!** She was the first to take the fruit, but she was also the first to turn back and make a different choice. We all fail, that's really nothing new, but we don't all turn back to God. Eve, Mother of all living-ones, is famous for Genesis 3:6-7, but she was also the first to **receive** the fruit. Welcome home! I say "Welcome home" because Eden is a place where heaven and earth overlap. A place where human and divine work together as one (yachad in Hebrew). It has always been more than just a physical spot on the map. Let's bring life to the next generation together!

Here are the pattern breaker choices in the first cycle of the melody, starting with Eve.

Chapters	Distinctive Notes
Genesis 4:25-26	4:25 and Adam (<i>the personal name, not the characteristic Human</i>) knew his wife again and she gave birth to a son (<i>yalad ben</i>), and she named him "Seth (<i>שֵׁת</i>)," because, "God has appointed (<i>תָּש</i>) me another seed in place of Abel, for Cain killed him." 26 and to Seth, to him also a son was born (<i>yalad ben</i>); and he called his name Enosh. then it was begun, to call on the name of Yahweh. Eve and Seth are living out only the second half of Genesis 3:16, the necessary labor pains, instead of the greatly multiplied grief of conception that we saw in 4:1-24. In your life too expect unavoidable labor pains as we humans learn to be images of God, but do try to avoid the greatly multiplied grief that comes when you conceive your own plans over trusting God's word. 3:16 and to the woman he said, [Part 1] "I will greatly multiply your grief and your conception (<i>הרה</i> <i>harah</i>), [Part 2] in grief you will birth children (<i>yalad benim, sons</i>), If these phrases were used only in this verse, the mystery would have been impossible to unravel, but that's not how the Bible works. The authors slowly reveal additional information as stories repeat to invite hearers to become active participants. For example, these subtle "conceive" vs "bear a son" word choices will echo not just in chapter four with Eve herself, but with other mothers in Scripture. To conceive is not a 100% match for pending great anguish, but it's a hint used more than a few times. Consider: Avram and Hagar conceive with Ishmael, Genesis 16:4, but Abraham and Sarah conceive and bear a son with Isaac, 21:2. David and Bathsheba initially conceive a child who died on the seventh day, 2 Samuel 11:5, but later bear a son, Solomon in 12:24-25. The later stories inform the earlier Genesis 3:16 mystery. <i>[Footnote: comically this is similar to how backpropagation is used today in training neural networks.]</i> As a teacher, I can identify this technique of putting an initial puzzle before students, a little mystery to figure out. These authors have intentionally crafted a learning experience to find linked words that unlock a cryptic statement. Focusing on ten words at a time doesn't work, you need the greater narrative. sure enough in Hebrew these words of Genesis 3:15a are ten words to the woman split 3-4-3. Much like The Ten Words, the 10 Commandments, these ten Hebrew words from Genesis 3:16 take time and effort to unpack. Hummm... a little riddle that requires you to take time to unpack used for teaching... that sounds familiar. Have you read the Sermon on the Mount recently? Is it any surprise that Jesus grew up immersed in this culture and way of teaching? There is more truth available as you spend time with the teaching. "He who has ears to hear let him hear!" Matthew 11:15. Anyway... with these patterns in mind, we return to Genesis 4:25-26, where Seth and Enosh are on God's chosen path. They are sons,

	think John 1:12, who experience only necessary labor pains. They avoid the great anguish seen in 4:1-24 with self made plans. Let's see how God will work through these pattern breaker choices in the generations that follow.
Genesis 5:22-24	5:22 and Enoch walked with God three hundred years ... 23 and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years, 24 and Enoch walked with God; and he was not, for God took him.
Genesis 6:1-7:5	6:13 And Elohim said to Noah, ... <i>(build an ark, a mini cosmos)</i> ... 22 And Noah did according to all that Elohim had commanded him, so he did. 7:1 And Yahweh said to Noah, ... <i>(fill that space with inhabitants)</i> ... 5 And Noah did according to all that Yahweh had commanded him. And Noah did it! That's all we needed to know.

God preserves a remnant to partner with him in the next melody cycle, and the pattern breakers are that remnant. The prophets will later develop this concept at length [for example Genesis 7:23 → Isaiah 11:10-11 or Micah 4:7], but the theme is planted right here in Genesis. They will join God to rebuild the cosmos when he does it again!

Genesis 8-11: The Second Round of the Melody

Before we jump into the second cycle of the melody, I'd like to pause for a moment and congratulate you for making it to the center of the center of this guide. We find ourselves in Genesis chapter 8, section 8 of this guide, and it feels symbolic, as if very early in the morning on the first day of a new week, the dawn of new creation. It's Sunday morning! We're hopeful like the 8th son of Jesse. Give us something new! I sure hope something important happens! ... Sure enough, something truly remarkable and significant will happen. Genesis 1 will replay in Genesis 8:1-9:18, but in new ways for a new generation. A pattern is not a pattern unless it repeats. So in Genesis 1-11, the introduction to the Bible, we see the cycle of life, not once, but twice. The Hebrew Bible authors are quietly going to reshape the way you see the world. The Spirit has breathed into them a truth that God never stops bringing creation, life, and blessing. Let's reflect on their words and try to become listeners that live out Psalm 1:1-1:3.

The cycle begins again in Genesis 8:1, unmistakably, right in the chiastic center of the flood narrative.⁸ Life begins with the presence of God, shown again as [Ruakh \(רוח\)](#), the Hebrew word that means wind, breath, or presence.

Additionally, we introduce a new highly significant word, [zakar](#), which means not just “remembered,” but more accurately “remembered and acted on it!”⁷

8:1 “And Elohim **remembered** (zakar) Noah
and all the living creatures
and all the beasts that were with him in the ark;
and Elohim caused to pass
a Spirit/wind ([Ruakh](#)) to cover the land
and the [waters](#) subsided.”

To help you compare the two “about to act” creation moments, here is the precreation state of Genesis 1:2, where the Ruakh was over the face of the waters.

1:2 Now, [the land](#) was wild and waste (תהו ובהו • *tohu va-vohu*),
and [darkness](#) was over the face of the [deep abyss](#) (תהום • *tehom*),
but the breath ([Ruakh](#)) of Elohim was hovering over the face of the [waters](#) (המים)

This guide is not a deep dive on the [Holy Spirit](#), the third person of the Trinity, for that consider a work like Tyler Staton’s **The Familiar Stranger**.¹⁰ However, I do want to at least point out that the Spirit did not come only after Jesus’ death at Pentecost in Acts 2. The same Spirit has been present and active since page one, doing what God does best, breathing life into His creation.

By the way, props to the 16th-century Bible scholars who chose to put the first melody into exactly seven chapters. Well done!

Next, Elohim commands Noah and his family to go out from the ark, blessing them Genesis 1 style:

9:1 And Elohim **blessed** Noah and his sons and he said to them,
“[Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the land.](#)”

All is good in blissful Creation at the top of the mountain with God. However, it makes an informed reader wonder what will come next... and worry. The authors continue the Creation, Choice, Division of Relationships, and Collapse cycle using very clear notes.

In the second pass through the melody, Genesis 8-11, notice that the authors never replay a story identically. Each cycle fills out the one before, quietly expanding your sense of what each note is communicating. By the end of only two laps, you’ll reflect back on Genesis 1-7 in ways that you couldn’t see before.

Name	Chapters	Distinctive Notes
Melody Cycle 2 Creation 	Genesis 8:1-9:18	We again hear Creation notes of blessing, but with a new twist, the humans and animals are partnering with God in the creation process. In Genesis 1:27 when Elohim created the ‘Image of God,’ the Imago Dei in Latin, the authors used the phrase “male and female” he created them. That phrase in Hebrew is za-KAR oonKAY vah (זָכָר וּנְקֵבָה) and it became a creation note that we should listen for. In this new creation story, Noah is bringing out the animals who were put into the ark za-KAR oonKAY vah, male and female. The repeated words are creation vocabulary that the authors didn't want you to miss. In fact they repeat the phrase four times when the animals board the boat, za-KAR oonKay vah. By the way, we are stepping around the rabbit hole where the letters for zakar, זָכָר, mean both “male child” from this phrase AND zakar זָכָר, “remembered,” in Genesis 8:1, too many hyperlinks! But a listener in Hebrew would certainly hear the zakar creation notes. These new creation events continue in blissful harmony with a sacrifice, covenant, and a sign of the covenant, the rainbow. What could go wrong? However, we know the cycle will repeat since Genesis 8:21 warns us that the human heart has not changed.
Melody Cycle 2 Choice 	Genesis 9:19-29	The next generation repeats the sins of the old as the Choice notes begin to play in the new Eden space. Noah takes the wine in an illicit way by getting drunk. Then he uncovers himself in the middle of his tent. These are verbal echoes of Adam and Eve taking the fruit in the middle of the garden, then realizing they were naked. Finally, Ham “saw the nakedness of his father”. In Hebrew, a man's nakedness is his wife, Leviticus 18:7-8 spells this out plainly. The act is so terrible that the authors use a common Hebrew euphemism. Despite our modern debates and mystery, “seeing the nakedness” is a standard phrase stating that Ham had sex with his father's wife [if you would like to have more evidence go read Ezekiel 22:9-11]. The word choice ties this unthinkable moment into the “seeing what is good in his eyes” theme. Translators face an impossible task here. They need to maintain the “seeing” hyperlink, discern the idioms, and keep it to five words or less. So they usually just follow the pattern of prior translations, throw their hands in the air, and give a literal word-for-word translation, leaving interpretation to the reader (which is fine, let commentaries explain it). Next, much like God did in the Garden exit, this new state results in Noah giving blessings to Yahweh the Elohim of Shem and curses to Canaan. Wait, Canaan? Where did Ham go? Canaan, the father of the Canaanites, was Ham's fourth and final son, but the authors don't explain the generational jump at all. Instead, you are forced to use your imagination to fill in the gap.
Melody Cycle 2 Division 	Genesis 9:22-11:5	It is no surprise that Division comes next. In fact, it has already begun. Ham's horrific power play fractured the family, causing the three brothers to divide into the nations. The spiral continues with Nimrod building Babylon, the icon for communal evil choices used throughout the Bible. Finally, Yahweh does a thorough investigation of the situation in Genesis 11:5, “And Yahweh came down to see the city and the tower that <u>the sons of humanity built</u>.” Dangerous notes are beginning to play.

Melody Cycle 2 Collapse C ₃ 2	Genesis 11:7-9	In this cycle, the collapse is Yahweh scattering the civilization of Babylon at the Tower of Babel. 11:9 “from there Yahweh scattered them upon the face of all the land.” In our generation, scattering a nation doesn't carry the same weight, but in this context, these are Collapse notes. For example, in 9:19, the authors describe the “scattering” using the Hebrew word naphats , which Psalm 2:9 uses to “shatter” like a pot. So God shattered the people of Babylon like a pot onto the face of the land. God has initiated the collapse in both cycles so far to set the stage for new life, ⁹ but that will not always be the case as the melody continues.
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With only two passes through the melody, we can already hear many distinctive notes that emerge from Genesis 1-11. Here are only a few:



Enjoyable side quest: Go read the first two chapters of Luke, listening for **Creation** notes of Spirit, blessing, and **signs**. There are more than you might guess, and you'll wonder how you missed them before.

Genesis 8-11: Pattern Breakers!

Who are the pattern breakers in the second round of the melody and how will God preserve life through them? It is a shorter melody, so there are fewer pattern breakers, but we still see a few. We have Noah who builds an altar and makes a going-up offering to Yahweh. Yahweh smells the soothing smell and responds in blessing. This sacrifice note is mirrored in other rounds of the melody in creative ways. The next pattern breakers are Shem and Japheth. They do the opposite of Ham and cover their father's nakedness. This time, **not** seeing their father's nakedness is simple and literal. These authors use clever wordplay even when the subject matter makes us feel uncomfortable. Subtle symmetries, through repeated words, help readers see the inversion.

Afterwards, Noah blesses Yahweh the Elohim of **Shem** and again a remnant is preserved through Shem's line. Genesis 11:10-26 gives another ten-generation bridge, mirroring chapter 5. It is the tenth, Avram, who will partner with God to start the next melody cycle. Will Avram be the one who will crush the head of the snake?

Genesis 11:27-22:19: Cycles Three to Seven with Avraham

With Genesis 1-11 complete, we come to the next major section of Genesis and start the third cycle of the melody. It opens with a title in Genesis 11:27, "Now these are the generations of Terakh." Then, following the Genesis 1 pattern, we have a new precreation state in 11:28-32. This time, the symbols for non-life are not watery chaos or a dry desert. Instead, if you read with eyes looking for symbols of death and disorder, you will notice:

- And Haran **died** before his father Terakh
- And Sarai was **barren**, she had no child
- And they **went out ... to go to** the land of **Canaan**; and they went as far as **Haran**
- And Terakh **died** in Haran

Without God's presence, the "wild and waste" from Genesis 1:2 is depicted with these new symbols of precreation non-life. Genesis 12:1 then starts the **Creation** section of Melody with Yahweh speaking to Avram, who steps into the role of Adam and Noah. In this generation, he will partner with God to once again bring about **creation**, life, and blessing.

12:1 "And Yahweh said to Avram,
Get yourself going..."

It's a wonderful and significant speech, but a bit long for this guide. Go read it! It calls Avram to come out, much like Noah was called out of the Ark. Then Yahweh expands the new Creation promise, stating: "in you **all the families of the land** will find blessing". Verses 4 and 5 then tell another journey story, but now with God present. Interestingly, this second journey was perhaps the same trip, see Acts 7:2. This reminds me of Genesis 1:2 where darkness was over the face of the **tehom**, the waters of death, but the Spirit of Elohim was hovering over the face of the **waters**. Those might be the same physical states, just described first without God's presence and then with it. The difference is not what you would see with your eyes. The difference is God.

Next, Avram journeys throughout the land with Yahweh in Genesis 12:6-9, much like Adam and Eve walked with God in the windy part of the day. An informed reader enjoys the bliss of **Creation** notes, but is again worried about what will happen next. Yahweh makes a clear, unconditioned declaration in Genesis 12:7: "To your seed I will give this land." Will Avram trust and obey, staying in the land that Yahweh has promised? You already know. You have been shaped by the melody without even realizing it. The cycle will continue as long as the human heart is unchanged, but God will continue to preserve life through it all. The One who IS does not change.

We could continue discussing the melody with the **Choice** in Egypt of seeing, taking, and giving, then a **Division** of Relationships with the “brothers,” Avram and his nephew Lot, followed by a **Collapse** of four kings sweeping away five. Instead of continuing through the cycle in a linear way from this point, which is already getting pretty lengthy, let’s mention only the Collapse moments that mark the seven cycles of Genesis 1-22. Working through each full cycle with your own group is worth your time. The story takes a much closer look at one person and we see the complexity of humans as we are pattern breakers one moment, then go right back to being characteristic ten seconds later. The creative twists will be surprising and rewarding as you meditate on the melody. The seven Collapse stories of Genesis 1-22 are:

Name	Chapters	Distinctive Notes
Melody Cycle 1 Collapse 	Genesis 7:17-24	The Flood: 7:23 And he wiped away every standing-thing that was upon the face of the land, from humanity to animals to creepers and to birds of the skies, and they were wiped away from the land; and only Noah was left remaining, and those with him in the ark.
Melody Cycle 2 Collapse 	Genesis 11:8-9	The Scattering: 11:8-9 And Yahweh scattered them from there upon the face of all the land, and they stopped building the city. Therefore, its name was called Babylon (Babel), because there Yahweh made-babble of the language of all the land, and from there Yahweh scattered them upon the face of all the land.
Melody Cycle 3 Collapse 	Genesis 14:1-12	Sodom #1: Four kings from Mesopotamia waged war against five kings, which included the people, possessions, and food of Sodom and Gomorrah. Avram’s nephew Lot is taken in the process. This is our first collapse of human origin, but the flood language remains the same as they sweep away. Meanwhile, Avram is symbolically in the ark, but then goes out with 318 men and “God’s help” to restore life.
Melody Cycle 4 Collapse 	Genesis 16:6	Hagar #1: A rape victim, pregnant, fleeing in the wilderness with nowhere to go and no human that loves her in the world. Only Yahweh sees this Egyptian slave-girl. ⁷ In this fourth cycle of the melody the Choice, Division of Relationships, and Collapse happen in only six verses in 16:1-6. It’s an explosion where these authors can replay the whole story with very few words once you know the notes to listen for. A single choice by Sarai and Avram to take their Egyptian slave-girl Hagar causes a violent division of every relationship leading to a very sudden collapse. God, however, enters our mess, sees Hagar in the wilderness, and restores life in ways that feel interestingly compromised, making the best of a broken situation. Read this in-depth Hagar article for more insights.
Melody Cycle 5 Collapse	Genesis 19:15-29	Sodom #2: 19:24 and Yahweh caused it to rain over Sodom and over Gomorrah, sulphur and fire from Yahweh from the skies. The notes of this culminating collapse can’t be missed as it uses a flood of words to connect the melodies. Noteworthy in this story is that Lot and his family are saved due

		to Yahweh's mercy, 19:16, and the phrase "Yahweh remembered (zakar) Avraham " ⁸ is used in 19:29, when Avraham wasn't even there. These authors don't use words for no reason.
Melody Cycle 6 Collapse 	Genesis 21:14-16	Hagar #2: Hagar is this time sent into the wilderness with Ishmael, her, most likely, 17 year old boy lad, the Hebrew word na'ar. She is a slave-girl no longer and has her son with her, but the water runs dry and death seems inevitable. Does this remind you of Genesis 2:5, a lifeless desert with no water? But Elohim listens to the voice of the na'ar (a fun wordplay on the meaning of Ishmael's name), converting Collapse into Creation once more. The turning point is a messenger of Elohim calling to Hagar from the skies. Hagar is told not to be afraid, but to 'get up' and take the lad with her hand. Elohim will make him into a great nation. Sound familiar? The same promise was given to Avram. Elohim opened her eyes and she saw a well of water at Beer Sheva, the Well of Seven. She fills the water skin and she gives life to the lad as well. Not a single word is unimportant as Hagar, the non-choosen, becomes an unexpected partner in creation, life, and blessing.
Melody Cycle 7 Collapse 	Genesis 22:1-10	The Binding of Isaac: The seventh collapse is told one syllable at a time as Avraham sends out his hand and takes the eater, the knife, to slay his son. This collapse is brought about by God's command, which includes the words "Get yourself going..." precisely mirroring the initial calling of Avram. Hyperlinking all the way back to the start of his journey hints that everything in between has been leading up to this moment. Avraham's struggle to trust God is put to the ultimate test and God's song is again at the precipice of non-life as the promised seed is bound on the altar. When we open the pages to this collapse, we find quite a bit more than just a flood. The seventh collapse necessitates a more in-depth discussion to make sure we all see a bit more of what the authors are communicating.

The Melody Points to Jesus

Without really planning it, we'll carefully study the seventh melody and something will happen where the story naturally turns to Jesus. Let's ride the wave together.

The Seventh Collapse: Avraham's Test

As you might have suspected, the seventh collapse of the melody and the creation moment after are rather significant. Without even knowing the rest of the story, a careful reader of the Hebrew Bible would know that when this melody repeats, it will reveal God in a **major** way. Indeed, the concept of The Melody and The Test are two different topics, but they are so interwoven here that we have no choice but to jump into Genesis 22:1-19 with both feet! Take a moment to read those 19 verses again, then we'll discuss.

In the text below the name **Isaac** is written as **Yitskhaq** to help us more faithfully pronounce the original Hebrew name.

22:1 And it came about after these things,
that Elohim **tested** Avraham,

and he said to him,
"Avraham."

And he said,
"Look, it's me!"

2 And he said,
"Please **take your son,**
your only one,
whom you love,
Yitskhaq,

and get yourself going to the land of **Moriah** ["Seeing" = (מריה)],
and **make him go up there as a going-up offering,**
on one of **the mountains which I will say to you."**

3 And Avraham rose early in the morning,
and he bound up his **donkey,**
and he **took**
two of his **young men** with him
and **Yitskhaq his son,**
and he split the **wood** of **the going-up offering,**
and he arose and he went to **the place which Elohim said to him.**

4 On the third day,
then Avraham **lifted his eyes,**
and he saw (ראה) **the place** from a distance.

5 And Avraham said to his young men,
"Sit yourselves here with the **donkey,**
and I and the **young boy,**
we will go to there,
and **we will** worship,
and **we will** return to you."

6 And Avraham took the **wood** of **the going-up offering,**
and he placed upon **Yitskhaq his son,**
and he took in his hand the **fire** and the **eater [= knife],**
and the two of them went, together as one.

7 **And Yitskhaq said to Avraham his father,**
and he said,
"My father."

And he said,
"Look, it's me, **my son."**

And he said,
"Look, the **fire** and the **wood,**
but where is the **sheep** for **the going-up offering?"**

8 **And Avraham said,**
"Elohim **will see to it** (יראה), the **sheep** for **the going-up offering, my son."**
And the two of them went, together as one.

9 And they went to **the place which Elohim said to him**,
and Avraham built there an altar,
and he arranged the **wood**,
and he bound up **Yitskhaq his son**,
and he placed him upon the altar atop the **wood**,
10 and Avraham **sent out his hand**,
and he took the **eater [= knife]** to slay **his son**,

[Collapse]

[Creation]

11 **and the messenger of Yahweh called to him from the skies**,
and he said,
"Avraham! Avraham!"

and he said,

"Look, it's me!"

12 **And he said**,

"Don't send out your hand toward the young one!

And don't do anything to him,

because now I know that you are one who fears Elohim,

and you didn't withhold **your son, your only one**, from me."

13 And Avraham **lifted his eyes**,

and **he saw (ראה)**, and look, a **ram** afar, caught in a bramble by its horns,

and Avraham went and he took the **ram**,

and **he made it go up as a going-up offering** in the place of **his son**,

14 and Avraham called the name of **that place**,

"Yahweh **will see to it (יראה)**."

Which is why, today, it is said,

"On **the mountain of Yahweh**, **it will be seen to (יראה)**."

15 **And the messenger of Yahweh called to Avraham a second time from the skies**,

16 and he said,

"I swear an oath (שבוע) by myself, utterance of Yahweh,

on account of the fact that you did this thing,

and you did not withhold **your son, your only one**,

17 that I will certainly **bless** you,

and I will certainly **multiply your seed**,

like the stars of the skies,

and **like the sand upon the edge of the sea**,

and **your seed** will inherit the gate of their enemies,

18 and all the nations of the land will find **blessing** in your seed,

on the heel of the fact that you listened to my voice."

19 And Avraham returned to his young men,

and they arose **and they went together as one** to Beer-**Sheva** (=Well of **Seven (שבוע)**)

and Avraham dwelt in Beer-**Sheva**.

The collapse opens with a clear title in 22:1 stating that Avraham is [tested](#). When you think “test,” try to imagine an **experience that reveals the truth**, not a stressful exam with right and wrong answers. It reveals what is already present through action. For example, Noah was called **righteous** in 6:9 by the narrator, but he still had to actually build the Ark in 6:22 and Yahweh sees the truth in 7:1. Likewise, Avraham was called **righteous** in 15:6, but he would still have to go through his test in Genesis 22. God is giving him a quest to reveal truth, not tempting him to do evil. There is a difference. God is asking him to trust in His wisdom beyond anything he can see with his eyes. It is clearly not a test God would give you or me, but the test fits the man if you reflect on Avraham’s whole story. Jesus illustrated that tests are specific to the person when he spoke to the rich young ruler. That man’s test was based on the thing that separated *him* from God, his wealth. He needed to trust God and give away all he had to the poor, then follow Jesus. In his case, it only revealed his inability to take a radical step of trust, and he went away downcast. When God chose “Father Abraham” to initiate His restoration plan, he knew exactly what test would reveal him and he knew that Avraham would trust his voice. In the same way, The Father knew what test would reveal The Son and he trusted the Son to complete it. That test reveals God to us.⁹ Consider Psalm 22:31 and John 3:16.

The hyperlinks from Genesis 22 to Jesus are impossible to miss. It is a test for both the father and the son. However, they traveled together perfectly aligned, both before and after all the details are known. The phrase “and the two of them went, together-as-one” (yachad in Hebrew) is repeated three times. Isaac put the wood on his back and walked with his father at the same physical place where Jesus will later be lifted up on the cross. Keep in mind that all of this was written hundreds of years before Jesus ever walked the earth. That’s worth a long walk and a cup of tea. Finally, Avraham’s collapse and Jesus’ collapse end the same way, the son is returned to life. Avraham is revealed. Elohim sees. And a going-up offering of a ram substitutes for Avraham’s offspring. As always, God makes sure that creation, life, and blessing have the final say over a collapse.

Before we leave this story, let’s consider what it might have meant to Jesus. What thoughts raced through Jesus’ head as he mentally recounted this story in the Garden of Gethsemane? And when did He fully grasp the details? John the Baptist publicly named Jesus as the “Lamb of God” in John 1:29. I think Jesus knew **fully** what that meant. Yahweh’s character has been known since Exodus 34:6-7, but Jesus would still have to go through the test. This plan, made before time began, is how God would reveal who He is to us. God loves you. He has said it in His Word, and He has shown it in His actions. He has passed the test to show that nothing will separate Him from joining us even when he knows it’s coming.

Then the outpouring of blessings given by God's oath "on the heel" of **the test** is worth reading a few times. Genesis 22:16-18, Yahweh's Oath (שבוע **sheva**) at the conclusion of Melody seven (שבוע **sheva**):

[1] 22:16 "I swear an oath (שבוע **sheva**) by myself, utterance of Yahweh,
on account of the fact that you did this thing,
[2] and you did not withhold your son, your only one,
[3] 17 that I will certainly bless you,
[4] and I will certainly multiply your seed,
like the stars of the skies,
and like the sand upon the edge of the sea,
[6] and your seed will inherit the gate of their enemies,
[7] 18 and all the nations of the land will find blessing in your seed,
on the heel of the fact that you listened to my voice."

Let's read it again, "**all nations** will find blessing **in your seed**." The author wants you to remember Genesis 3:15 by mentioning the words "heel" and the future "seed" so close together. Two words are more than enough to see this connection.

3:15 And I will set hostility
between you and the woman,
and between your seed and her seed,
he will strike your head
and you will strike his heel."

However, the people would have to wait a long time until God repeats these specific notes. The Genesis Melody won't fail, but it does require waiting patiently for God's *teleios* timing.

Seeing the Melody in the New Testament

We'll briefly pause our review of Genesis and consider **The Genesis Melody** as it plays out in the Gospel According to Luke. You probably know that cycle of the melody well.³ In Luke, the story opens with God's Spirit creating life in two impossible places of non-life: a barren womb long past childbearing and one that had never known a man. Luke starts, not just with the birth of Jesus to the virgin Mary, but with the interwoven story of John the Baptist's birth to Zechariah and Elizabeth. The author of this story saw that even the names of the parents were significant:

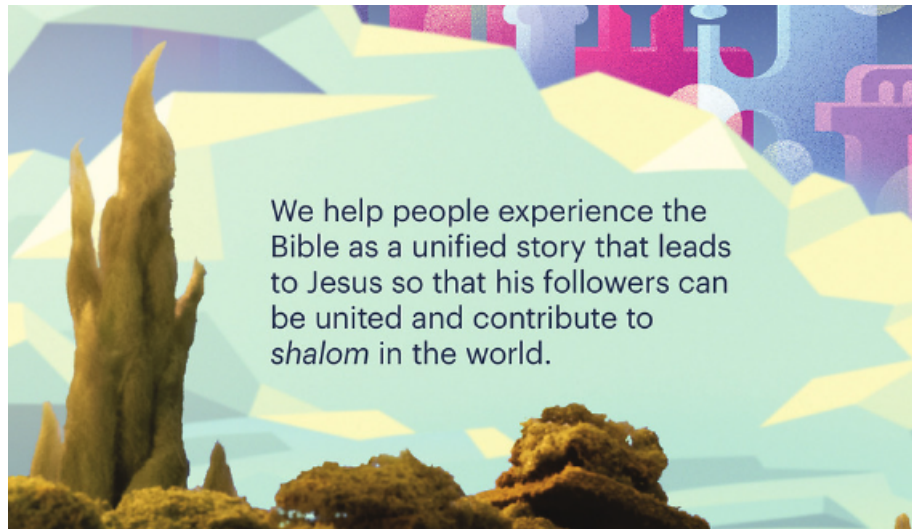
- Zechariah, from the Hebrew Zakar-Yah זכריה, means "Yahweh Remembered, zakar."⁸ It's that zakar word again, the one that means "acts on his promise." Compare that with Genesis 8:1, "Elohim remembered, zakar, Noah"⁸ or 19:29, "Yahweh remembered, zakar, Avraham."
- Elizabeth, from the Hebrew Eli-Sheva אלישבע, means "My Elohim's Oath". It's that sheva, **oath**, word again! Compare that with 22:16, "I swear an oath (שבע sheva)."

Zechariah and Elizabeth are set up as clear mirrors of Avraham and Sarah, childless at a good old age. And if you put their names together, you literally have "Yahweh Remembered His Oath *from Genesis 22!*" OK, I admit, I added that last bit, but "Zechariah Elizabeth" means that Yahweh made good, delivered on, remembered his oath to Abraham in Jesus and John was the forerunner of that good news.

The authors who handed over source material to the **gentile** Luke, see Luke 1:1, saw the Genesis melody at work. They partnered with Luke to share the Good News about Jesus to **all the nations** via the same **Creation** notes that echo Genesis, now appearing in Luke, chapters 1 and 2. Luke's story then has a **Choice** in the wilderness for forty days and a matching **Test** in Gethsemane before the end. There is a journey with Jesus, just like Avram's journey with Yahweh, and a **Division** with the leaders of Israel (that's putting it lightly). Then a reply of the seventh cycle **Collapse** at the cross.⁶ Finally, this is the most important part, what comes **after** a Collapse? The author of life allows His own body, His Son, to experience Collapse, from which God will... You know exactly what happened next, on the third day no less, see Genesis 22:4. **The Genesis Melody** has been written in Scripture for a thousand years. Jesus surely said many similar things on the road to Emmaus in Luke 24, as he "opened the Scriptures" to his disciples.³

As for me, when this really sank in, it made me want to be a pattern breaker, join **God's** story, and be part of the work He is doing. I've carefully read, reflected on, and discussed His Word. I now see myself within this grand message of hope and love. I've been promised that it is possible to help bring life. I choose to live in right-relationship with Yahweh. I am part of Avraham's seed and want to do my part in bringing blessing to the nations. Now,... how do I do it? How can I receive the Spirit, partner with God, and bring about creation, life, and blessing in my generation? It sounds complex, but the first step is actually easy,... trust Jesus, listen to His voice.

No word from the Lord is unimportant, so it's wise to study the New Testament even more diligently than the Old. When studying His word you'll find Wisdom for finding life and see the path Jesus laid out for his followers for then and now. For example, Jesus prayed aloud His plan for us during the Last Supper, recorded in John 17:20-26. Life is an intentional choice to be **united through love with God and His images**. Jesus knew that we needed encouragement to avoid the Division of Relationships. He had seen the Bible's message play out in his generation, just like us. Perfect unity through abiding (meno) love between all the images of God with the Father and the Son. Everything else in the Bible is an implementation detail of that simple, primary premise. We have to choose unity in Jesus to avoid the characteristic human cycle. That plan also reminds me of something we like to say at BibleProject:



However, when I look at my life, how I use my time, where I invest my given resources,...

Do I make the **Choice** that leads to life with every little choice I make?

Do I contribute to **Division** and fear **Collapse**?

Do I have eyes to see and ears to hear God's melody?

What is God clearly going to do next?

He does not prevent the Collapse, *even though that seems good in our eyes*, but instead He **goes through it with us** and there will be a genesis coming soon after. Will we choose to trust God in even this?

Let the Bible reshape your understanding of the world, so that you can know|love Him more.

Make a [Choice](#) to become an image of God who **receives** to see **good**, then **builds** and **gives** in every part of the melody.

Beyond Genesis 22: After the Sheva Cycle

The melody in Genesis, of course, doesn't end in chapter 22. If you read Matthew 24:1-14, it's clear Jesus knew the inevitable path of typical human choices across every generation, and he prepared his disciples for what was coming. The cycle would not end even with Jesus' resurrection. Something did change that day, but the difference is not what you would see with

your eyes. Hearts aren't changed in our world today either, so every generation, including ours, faces the same challenges. Yahweh, the one who IS, has always known the answer, and He has made it known to us through His Son, completing a test, revealing the truth. God really loves you.

After the mountaintop, you should also read chapter 23. It is a wonderfully symbolic story about paying the full price for the land. You can meditate with me about why that is important. How does that square with Yahweh promising to just give the land in Genesis 12:7 and 17:8 (or Ezekiel 11:17)? Shouldn't we just receive the free Eden gift? Interestingly, Avraham, like David later, declines the offer and is steadfast to pay the full price. They both refuse to make an offering/sacrifice that costs them nothing. Do I get it? **Not yet.** However, I [feel](#) like we should consider this story as significant after the 1-22 melody cycles. My random thoughts that maybe your group could build off of:

- Both men have messed up pretty badly in their story so far.
- It seems like a good gesture, a good first step.
- I'm not sure if money alone will change the human heart though.
- Jesus didn't really ask for money.
- I wonder if these stories connect to the woman who bought the perfume, Joseph of Arimatham, Zaccueus, or Nicodemus.
- Priests don't eat anything torn by wild animals, does this choice connect to that?
- I wonder what our world would be like if a billion people woke up tomorrow choosing to pay the full price for our land. I wonder what that world would be like.

Anyway, the story keeps going after Genesis 23. The eighth melody cycle, 22:20-25:18, ends with Avraham's death and the scattering of his various sons. He takes a third wife and has six more sons in chapter 25 (oh my). The biblical authors aren't selling "happily ever after" stories; they are communicating the choices we humans make and how God works through it all (consider Jacob!). After Avraham is old and complete (*sheva*), he is "gathered to his people" in 25:8. The melody, however, continues generation after generation with Rivqah (Rebecca) and Yitskhaq (Isaac), then Jacob and Esau, Judah and Joseph, and on into our lives.

Extra Sheva Observations

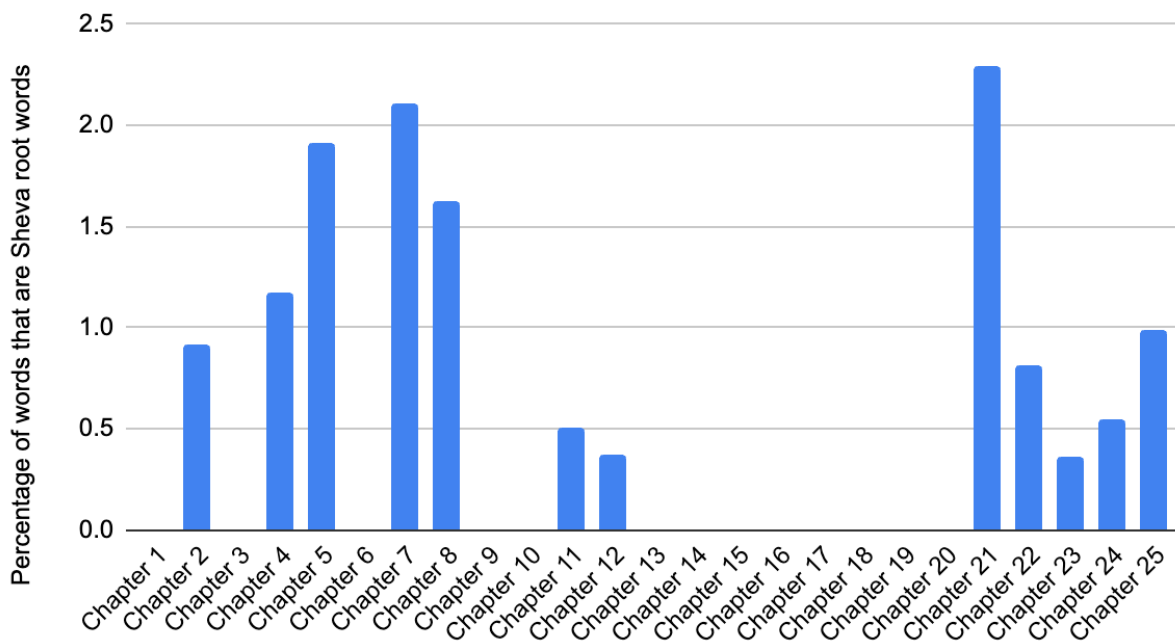
To bring this discussion full circle, let's return to Genesis once more to see evidence that these authors, with the help of the Spirit, already realized the significance of this forward pointing message in Genesis 21-22.

Throughout Scripture the authors regularly highlight the most important concept of a literary unit by using key repeated words, known as **lead words**. In this seventh cycle of the melody, which goes from the voice in the sky bringing life to Hagar and Ishmael, through the binding of Isaac, the primary lead word is clearly **sheva**. The same Hebrew letters of *sheva*, שבע, form multiple Hebrew words. Think of it like the English letters *lead*, which has multiple meanings: lead the way, pencil lead, or leader. The Hebrew word *sheva*, שבע, means [seven](#), [oath](#), and, later,

[completion](#), making it a very significant word. Perhaps you've noticed the number 7 gets used a lot.

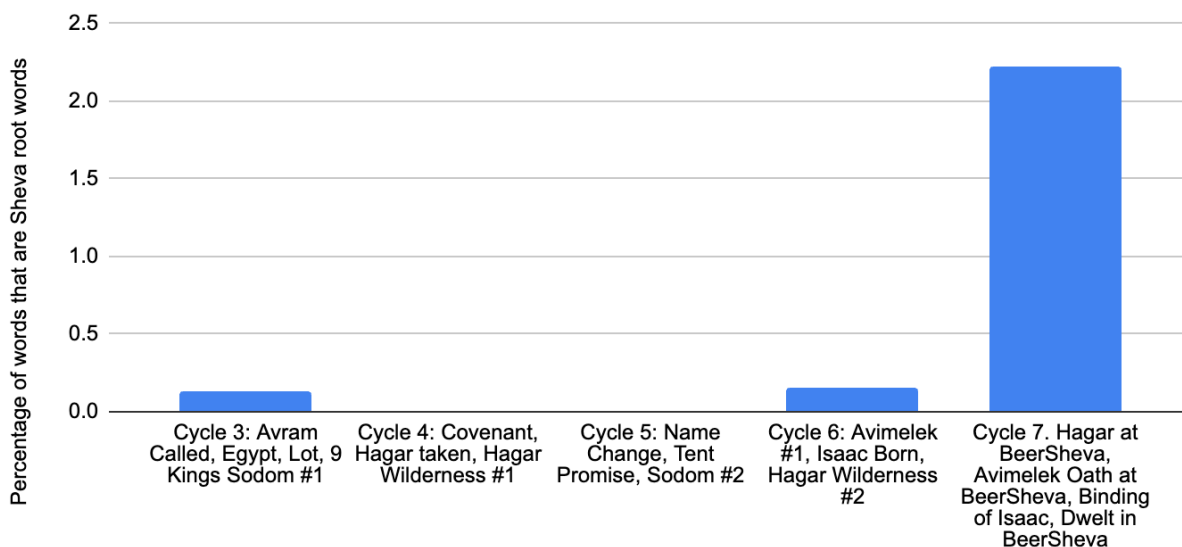
The sheva theme is everywhere in this melody cycle. The Creation notes opens with Hagar and Ishmael at Beer-Sheva, the Well of Seven. The middle section with Avimelek takes place at Beer-Sheva, centered on an oath, a sheva. Then, after the mountain in Moriah, the literary unit ends with Avraham dwelling in Beer-Sheva. The start, middle, and end are all at Beer-Sheva. Everything points to Yahweh's culminating sheva, His oath. In addition to the location, there are more sheva words used in Genesis 21-22 than you might guess. The numbers tell the story:

Use of Sheva words by Genesis Chapter



And if you focus on only the use of sheva words in cycles three to seven with Avraham it becomes clear that the authors have intentionally marked this round of the melody as the Sheva Cycle.

Use of Sheva words by Melody Cycle



By modern writing standards, the repeated use of sheva borders on excessive, but that's exactly the point. Listeners would hear the word as prominent and realize this is the seven-oath for completion. Imagine sitting in the temple courts on Sabbath listening to Simeon read this text. The word sheva appears 10 times within the cycle, with the 10th being Yahweh's Sheva. Did Simeon emphasize each one for his hearers?

Let's look at one example from Genesis 21:28-32, a "seemingly" insignificant passage.

7 28 And Avraham set up **seven** (שבע) female lambs of the flock alone,
 7 29 and Avimelek said to Avraham, "What are these **seven** (שבע) female lambs that you have set up alone?"
 7 30 And he said, "Because the **seven** (שבע) female lambs you will take from my hand,
 ➡ so that it will become a **witness** (עדה) on my behalf, that I dug this **well**."
 7 31 For this reason, one calls that place "Beer-Sheva" [Well (באר) of Seven (שבע)]
 7 because there **the two of them** swore an oath (שבע).
 7 32 And **they cut a covenant** at Beer-Sheva, (באר שבע).

The authors use extra sheva, שבע, words surrounding being a **witness**. That'll preach! In this story, these two men, whose names mean Father of Nations and My Father is King, also make the first human-v-human covenant in the Bible. They mend the Division cycle without directly mentioning God. That's interesting! The Test and the Collapse are still coming in Genesis 22, Abraham has made a lifetime of Choices that need resolution, but we see a glimmer of hope in chapter 21 about how to slow down this crazy hamster wheel... covenant relationships. Covenants aren't as good as changed hearts, but usually it's the best option we have available.

When we are outside of Eden, it's the only thing we can do to keep from killing each other. Every generation has to renew a covenant, Isaac and Avimelek in Genesis 26, Jacob and Lavan in Genesis 31, and on into today. This seventh cycle is packed with insights! Perhaps a better way to view Genesis 1-22 is as seven creation moments. The first is Genesis 1:1. The seventh, complete, oath genesis was the one that points to Jesus fulfilling the Genesis Melody.

I'll let you be the judge. Did these authors realize that when our Father listened to the voice of Ishmeal and asked Abraham to begin his Test, it was also the seventh cycle of the melody? Did they count melodies from the beginning and intentionally work with the Spirit to reveal God to you? How did they know, even then, to write the text in this way? I'm not gonna lie, this kinda blows my mind. The seventh, culminating, oath cycle about fulfillment points to Jesus. It is the highly structured Word of God given to us by humans working with the Ruakh of Elohim after all.¹ And when Jesus read his Bible he figured that out! I'm beginning to believe Luke 24 that this whole story is about Him.

Your Next Steps

God's not finished and we're not done. Let's talk about next steps. There is quite a bit more Bible to learn from after these opening chapters and there is an endless amount of work to do once we are prepared to do it.. Spend time laying your foundation and then expect to keep going.

To learn more about the melody, if you can find a group of people that like to read the Bible, don't passively read anything else from us. Go do it!⁴ Read directly from God what the Spirit has breathed.¹¹ Grab a friend, sit down with your family, or work with a small group to read Genesis 1-23 again, listening for the melody woven throughout these narratives. Ideally, your reading community should have a variety of veteran and novice readers, plus a diversity of people to see different angles, but sometimes just be happy with what you've got. Use any translation you like. For my group, we use the BibleProject Classroom translations. They are colorful, hyperliteral translations that help us see the structure behind the Wisdom of God. In the past, we have used a website I made, <https://thegenesismelody.web.app/avraham.html>, which links to those Classroom translations. Today, however, they are available in a new beautiful format right within the BibleProject app. We hope you and your group can DELIGHT in using it (inside joke, just go with it).

If you do find yourself in a situation where you don't have people around you today that you can read the Bible with, then spend time watching and learning from the Genesis Classroom courses. Start at the beginning with [Heaven and Earth](#) and make sure you get all the way to [Jacob](#), then re-read this guide. They will change the way you read the rest of the story! Just visit <https://bibleproject.com/classroom/> on the website or use our mobile app.

Have fun falling in love with these amazing, and sometimes challenging, texts. When you approach the rest of the Hebrew Bible and the New Testament, what you get out of it depends a

lot on the [reading skills](#) you have developed. Becoming a **better community of receivers** takes work, but it's worth it. We all learn differently, but establish a foundation with the Bible's introduction and it will help so many stories lock into place. For example, when you read in John 20:22 that Jesus "breathed on them," you'll see even more. Why did he breathe on them? That's weird right? Nope. It's exactly what you should've expected if you knew the Genesis Melody the way Jesus knew the Genesis Melody. He gives his Ruahk, his breath/Spirit to his disciples so that he can become one with them to empower them as he sends them into the world to represent Him. He is symbolically replaying the Creation notes, His Ruahk in the remnant as they partner with Him to bring about creation, life, and blessing to the next generation. Here we go again and what a ride they had! Your turn!

By spending time meditating on the Bible's introduction, we've already begun to know|love Him more. Of course, real change comes when you personally partner with God and live it out by loving your neighbor, the image of God sitting right next to you. This is a test we all know is coming. What will it reveal in you that is already present?

Closing Thoughts

A Short Farewell Prayer

As the thief said on the cross:

Jesus, **remember**⁸ us when You come into Your kingdom.

We choose to follow you. Let's do it again!

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